

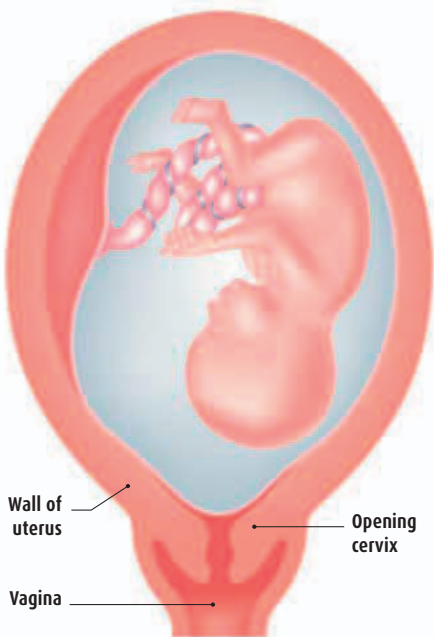
Q What are the types of miscarriage?

There are different terms for different types of miscarriage, which can be confusing at a time when you are likely to feel vulnerable and upset. Being familiar with these terms can help you to feel more informed, which in turn can help you cope better.

The two main types of miscarriage are inevitable and missed miscarriages. With an inevitable miscarriage, the cervix begins to open up before the baby is viable, and once this happens, it is unlikely that the pregnancy can be saved. This can happen during the first or second trimester. A missed miscarriage (also called a delayed or silent miscarriage) occurs when the embryo or fetus stops developing, but remains inside the uterus; this type of miscarriage is most common during the first 12 weeks of pregnancy. The developing baby dies without any clear warning signs for the mother that something has gone wrong. For a time

(sometimes days, or even weeks), the baby remains in the uterus, and the mother may continue to think that her pregnancy is progressing. Or typical early pregnancy symptoms may suddenly disappear, which may alert the mother to something being wrong. If at any time you have an instinctive sense that something is wrong, call your doctor.

A miscarriage is often a process rather than a single event. Sometimes bleeding may resolve itself (threatened miscarriage, see p.306) or bleeding may come and go and you may feel confused about what is happening. Alert your doctor to bleeding at any stage of pregnancy.



Opening cervix The most common type of miscarriage happens when the cervix opens spontaneously to stop a pregnancy that hasn't developed properly.

INEVITABLE AND MISSED MISCARRIAGES

Having an understanding of what happens in different situations can help you process events and understand your treatment options.

TYPE	WHAT HAPPENS	SYMPTOMS
Inevitable (complete or incomplete)	The cervix starts to open up before the baby is viable, and the uterus responds by contracting and starting to push out the developing fetus or embryo. This may be complete, when all of the pregnancy tissue (the embryo, sac, and placenta) is expelled, or incomplete, when some of the pregnancy tissue remains inside the uterus.	An inevitable miscarriage may be accompanied by severe periodlike pain, and is often accompanied by bleeding and clots.
Missed (also called a delayed or silent miscarriage)	The embryo or fetus stops developing, but remains inside the uterus. Eventually, the fetus dies, but with no clear warning signs, and the mother may continue to think that her pregnancy is progressing.	There may be no symptoms, or there may be a brown discharge, and pregnancy symptoms such as nausea, breast pain, and fatigue may suddenly disappear.

Q What are the causes of a miscarriage, and are there factors that increase my risk?

Around 80 percent of miscarriages that take place in the first 12 weeks of pregnancy, known as early miscarriage, occur because there is a chromosomal irregularity with the developing fetus. The baby may have too many or too few chromosomes, which means that there is incomplete chromosomal information, and as a result the baby is unable to develop properly.

A miscarriage in the second trimester, known as a late miscarriage, is more likely to have had another trigger, and is often the result of an underlying health problem or condition in the mother. There are several possible reasons for a late miscarriage, including:

- » If you develop an infection.
- » If you have a preexisting condition, such as thyroid disease, polycystic ovary syndrome, or diabetes, that increases the risk of miscarriage.
- » If you have a weakened cervix.
- » If you have a problem with your uterus,

such as a structural abnormality.

» If you have an immunological or endocrine disorder.

There are also several other factors that increase your risk of miscarriage. These include maternal age—you are at a greater risk of miscarriage over the age of 35—and lifestyle choices. For example, being obese increases your risk of miscarriage, as does smoking during pregnancy, taking recreational drugs, or drinking alcohol. Drinking caffeine is also thought to be a risk factor in whether you might have a miscarriage.